

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Book Intros)

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

Philippians

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How do you live as a Christian in a world that does not follow Christ? How do you respond when people around you oppose your faith? Paul wrote this sincere and personal letter to encourage the suffering Christians in Philippi and to strengthen them during difficult times. Paul wrote while he was in prison. He also was suffering for his faith. Even so, he showed that Christians can have joy in Christ in every situation.

Setting

Philippi was a small Roman colony in Macedonia, a region in northeastern Greece. It was about 16 kilometers (10 miles) inland from the Aegean Sea. The city was important because it stood along the Via Egnatia, the main Roman road that crossed Macedonia from east to west.

Paul first brought the good news about Jesus to Philippi during his second missionary journey around AD 50 (see Acts 16:11–40). From the beginning, people opposed his preaching. During his short stay, Paul was put in prison and later asked to leave the city. Before he left, however, a group of new believers had formed (Acts 16:35–40).

About six years later, during his third missionary journey around AD 56–57, Paul visited Philippi again (see Acts 20:1–6). It is possible that he never saw the believers in Philippi again after that visit (but see 1 Timothy 1:3, written around AD 63).

Paul wrote Philippians while he was in prison. Epaphroditus had brought a financial gift from the Philippians to Paul. When Epaphroditus returned to Philippi, Paul sent this sincere letter with him to encourage the church. Paul knew the believers in Philippi were suffering because of their faith. He wanted to strengthen them by sharing his own experience as a prisoner for Christ.

Summary

After a short introduction (1:1–2), Paul thanks God for the Philippians and prays that they will continue to grow spiritually (1:3–11). He then explains how his imprisonment has helped spread the good news about Christ (1:12–19). Paul's greatest desire is to live and die for Christ, whatever happens to him (1:20–26). He tells the Philippians to remain strong as they also suffer for Christ (1:27–30). They should care for one another

and follow the example of Christ, who gave up his life for others (2:1–18).

Paul is eager to know how the Philippians are doing and to tell them how he is. He hopes to send Timothy and Epaphroditus to Philippi soon. Both men have shown they are willing to suffer for Christ (2:19–30).

Paul also warns the Philippians about some Jewish Christian teachers who insist Christians must follow the law of Moses in order to belong to God's people (3:1–3). Paul describes his former life, when he focused on obeying the law. Now he believes the most important thing is knowing Christ, sharing in Christ's suffering and death, and experiencing the power of Christ's resurrection both now and in the future (3:4–11). All believers should keep pursuing the full life found in Christ (3:12–4:1).

At the end of the letter, Paul encourages the Philippians to live with joy, prayer, and thanksgiving. They should focus their thoughts on the good gifts God has given them, even while suffering persecution (4:2–9). Paul thanks them for the gift they sent him. He says he has learned to be content in every situation, and he encourages them to learn to live this way (4:1–20). As in his other letters, Paul closes with praise to God, greetings to believers, and a blessing of grace from the Lord (4:21–23).

Date and Place of Writing

Ephesians, Philippians, Colossians, and Philemon are often called the Prison Letters because each letter mentions that Paul was in prison when he wrote it. Scholars do not fully agree about where or when these letters were written. Traditionally, many believe Paul wrote them in Rome while under house arrest around AD 60–62 and later during another imprisonment around AD 64–65.

More recently, some scholars have argued that Paul may have written them from Ephesus around AD 53–56. During Paul's long stay in Ephesus, he faced strong opposition and suffering (see Acts 19:23–41; 2 Corinthians 11:23–28).

Literary Unity

Some readers notice sudden changes in topic and tone in Philippians, especially in 3:2–4:3 and 4:10–20. Because of this, some scholars believe Philippians may combine several shorter letters joined together by an unknown editor. An early Christian writer named Polycarp also referred to Paul's "letters" to the Philippians. However, many scholars believe Philippians is one complete letter written by Paul. They point out

that Paul often changes subjects quickly in his writings as he responds to different concerns.

Meaning and Message

Paul writes from prison to Christians who are facing opposition. He encourages them to follow his example and attitude. By describing his courage, commitment, confidence, and contentment in prison, Paul teaches the Philippians how to respond to suffering. He shows that Christians can live with joy, peace, prayer, thanksgiving, and devotion to Christ in every circumstance.

Although Paul is in prison, he is not ashamed. Instead, he rejoices because his imprisonment has helped spread the good news about Christ. He wants to honor Christ boldly no matter what happens to him. Paul knows he has been called to live for Christ, and he considers it a privilege to suffer for Christ (see 1:12–26).

Even in prison, Paul longs to be completely filled with the life of Christ. He is willing to share in Christ's suffering and death, and he looks forward to experiencing the full power of Christ's resurrection. He trusts that one day he will be raised from the dead as Christ was raised (3:7–14).

Meanwhile, Paul has learned to be content in every situation. He depends on Christ and has found Christ's strength sufficient even during the most difficult situations (4:11–13).

Paul urges the Philippians to rejoice in the Lord as they experience opposition. They should not be anxious about anything. Instead, they should pray about every need and thank God. In this way, they will experience God's deep peace (see 4:4–9).